

Weekly Reading Reflections #6: Sergio Monterroso

Assessing Difficult History: James Longstreet Museum

The James Longstreet Society owns the Piedmont Hotel in Gainesville, GA which used to be the home of the Confederate Lieutenant General with the same name as the society. I mentioned in my past reflection of the Longstreet Museum how they have a room of Confederate memorabilia that has no purpose to the narrative that the museum is trying to push. In fact, it works counterintuitive to the narrative because Longstreet was a Reconstructionist after the war. So, why is it there?

It's important to remember that the Longstreet Museum is a museum of the “other” voice in terms of broader Civil War memory. Spectators are presented an awkward task of feeling sorrow for someone that fought for a cause so repugnant to human liberty, but it managed to accomplish this task – but through different manners for different people. For myself, the newspaper articles of an older Longstreet and Helen Dortch fighting against their own fellow Southerners who impugned Longstreet’s character were sufficient to make me feel bad for him. But, what about those from other viewpoints?

Is the purpose of the Confederate room a smaller narrative in a small narrative museum? For Confederate sympathizers, does that room make them feel bad for Longstreet because he was one of them and fought alongside the cause? For me to feel sympathy, I had to absolve Longstreet of his Confederate service (which is probably not ideal but necessary if I must feel emotional sympathy with him), but for others do they surround him with the Confederate aura that had turned against him? After all, the narrative of the museum is to cleanse the reputation of James Longstreet. So, maybe that room does serve a purpose as being the “other” voice in a museum that is centered around the “other” voice, it just so happens to be a voice that society would be better off without.

This line of thinking put into perspective how being the “other” in a museum is not always morally, ethically, or just generally good. In class, we discussed “other” voices such as the slave narrative in Colonial Williamsburg, who only recently included that difficult history. In this situation, the “other” voice is one oppressed by a hateful narrative and that wasn’t include in the museum because the difficult “other” voice detracts visitors. What is the reverse of that? The Longstreet Museum? Here, we have the incorporation of a difficult “other” that caters specifically to the glorifiers of that cause, despite its rancid history.

The second question of this reflection asks me to investigate what is left out, but for this museum I must turn this question on its head by asking whether this “other” narrative should be intentionally left out. Begrudgingly, the answer is a no. A museum is a text and so the interpretation of the text is left to the reader. In my last reflection, I discussed how the Longstreet Museum is a laboratory museum-type that provides the spectator with the material and leaves them with their own interpretations, as opposed to the temple museum that focuses on top-down “education” narratives. So, the narrative that the spectator walks away with is of their own perspective. This applies to the Confederate room. If you walk in and glorify Longstreet because he was a member of the cause, then that’s your interpretation of that room. It’s not a good one, but it’s certainly an interpretation.

For others, the room serves as an anchor to remind the spectator that while Longstreet was the victim of character assassination, he was, after all, a Confederate General. When I first went to the museum, this was not the interpretation that I walked away with because I had dismissed the room as “just Confederate junk” instead of engaging it. This allowed me to develop an unrestrained sorrow for Longstreet as if he’s a peer of mine, without thinking “wait a minute, he’s a Confederate leader... that’s what that room means.” Had the room been absent, I don’t think any other room in the museum could serve the purpose of being the anchor. Therefore, it is necessary to include and for visitors to engage in deeper thought with as opposed to making the same mistake that I had made when I first encountered it.

Another Thought on “What is Left Out?”

Why is the Museum silent on Longstreet’s actions in New Orleans when he led police forces against a White Leaguer insurrection? Does it counter the “other” narrative of the museum that Longstreet was just as much as a Confederate as his peers? After all, that’s why most of the Confederate sympathizers abandoned him after the Civil War. Maybe one sinister view of this left out history is that they’re cleansing his reputation by changing his actions? I need to ponder this and go back to the museum another day to consider this.

ⁱ In the following paragraphs, you will be reading my actual thought process because I wrote down this sentence of how the Confederate room serves no purpose in the museum besides decoration. By the end of the paper, I slowly come to the realization that nothing is included in a museum for decoration. Everything that is included or left out is a conscious decision with a narrative behind it – but the narrative behind the inclusion of this room is... not a great one. Continue reading and you’ll notice the moment my brain breaks.